



Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church Sunday School Department
Mahibere Kidusan North America Center
Campus Ministry

In the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit . One God, Amen!

Dogmatic Theology

2020-21

Semester 2



Course Content

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Creation and aseity of God

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- Mystery of Holy Communion



Mystery of Holy Communion

- Sacrament (Mystery) of Communion is the teaching that the bread and wine offered during Divine Liturgy change into the true body and blood of Jesus Christ.
- Instituted by Jesus Christ Himself during the “Last Supper”. **/Matt. 26:26-28/**
“Jesus took bread, and blessed it, and brake it, and gave it to the disciples, and said, Take, eat; this is my body. And he took the cup, and gave thanks, and gave it to them, saying, Drink ye all of it; For this is my blood of the new testament, which is shed for many for the remission of sins.”
- Received after every Sacrament



- A redeeming sacrament – must be received by all for the eternal inheritance of His kingdom:
 - **John 6:48** *“I am the bread of life.”*
 - **John 6:54** *“Whoever eats My flesh and drinks My blood has eternal life.”*
- Through Holy Communion, we abide in Jesus Christ:
John 6:56 *“He who eats My flesh and drinks my body, abides in Me and I in Him.”*
- Through Holy Communion, we become one in Christ:
“The cup of blessing which we bless, is it not the communion of the blood of Christ? The bread which we break, is it not the communion of the body of Christ? For we, though many, are one bread and one body; for we all partake of that one bread.” (1 Corinthians 10:16-18)



Mystery of Holy Communion

□ Grace & Benefits of the Holy Communion

- Even in this life, we have to partake of the body and blood of Jesus Christ to be considered living:
“Most assuredly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink His blood, you have no life in you.” (John 6:53)
- Holy Communion is a spiritual food that helps us grow in our spiritual lives.
“My flesh is food indeed and My blood is drink indeed.” (John 6:55)
- Our sins are remitted through Holy Communion. **(Matthew 26:26-28)**
“Jesus took bread, and blessed it, and brake it, and gave it to the disciples, and said, Take, eat; this is my body. And he took the cup, and gave thanks, and gave it to them, saying, Drink ye all of it; For this is my blood of the new testament, which is shed for many for the remission of sins.”



Mystery of Holy Communion

□ This is not an easy Mystery to understand and accept. That is why the Lord Jesus Christ taught a multitude that were gathered around Him, gradually (*John 6*):

- The night before He taught the multitude about this mystery, He fed 5000 with only five loaves of bread and two fish.
- The next day, He said to the multitude, ***“Labor not for the meat which perishes, but for that meat which endures unto everlasting life, which the Son of man shall give unto you.”***
- They asked, ***“what shall we do that we might work the works of God?”***
- He replied, ***“This is the work of God, that you believe on Him whom He sent.”*** When he said this, they asked Him for a sign.
- The Lord Jesus Christ said, ***“My Father gives you the true bread from heaven... and gives life unto the world.”*** When they heard this, they said, ***“...give us this bread.”***
- ***John 6:35 – “I am the bread of life”***
- ***John 6:48 – 53 “I am the bread of life. Your fathers did eat manna in the wilderness and are dead. This is the bread which comes down from heaven. If any man eat of this bread, he shall live forever; and the bread that I give is My flesh... Verily, verily, I say unto you, Except ye eat the flesh of the Son of man, and drink his blood, ye have no life in you.”***



□ This teaching was hard even for the disciples /John 6:60 – 69/:

- *Many therefore of his disciples, when they had heard this, said, This is a hard saying; who can hear it? From that time many of his disciples went back and walked no more with him.*
- *Then said Jesus unto the twelve, Will ye also go away? Then Simon Peter answered him, Lord, to whom shall we go? thou hast the words of eternal life. And we believe and are sure that thou art that Christ, the Son of the living God.*



Mystery of Holy Communion

□ Symbols of Holy Communion

- The bread and wine Melchizedek offered to God. (**Genesis 14:18**)
- The Passover lamb, and the blood sprinkled on the doorposts of the Israelites: (**Exodus 12**). That is why John the Baptist said of Christ:
 - **John 1:29** “Behold the Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world.”
- The manna that came down from heaven for the Israelites (**Exodus 16:16; John 6:49**)
 - They didn’t work for it, but they ate of it and lived for the moment.
- The animal sacrifice of the Old Covenant



Mystery of Holy Communion

- The Feast of Wisdom (**Proverbs 9:1-5**)
 - *“Wisdom hath builded her house, she hath hewn out her seven pillars: 2 She hath killed her beasts; she hath mingled her wine; she hath also furnished her table. 3 She hath sent forth her maidens: she crieth upon the highest places of the city, 4 Whoso is simple, let him turn in hither: as for him that wanteth understanding, she saith to him, 5 Come, eat of my bread, and drink of the wine which I have mingled.”*
- The Feast – is the Divine Liturgy
- Wisdom – is the Lord Jesus Christ:
 - *Anaphora of St. Epiphanius - “But Wisdom is our Savior, who redeemed us with the sacrifice of His body, and bought us with the sprinkling of His blood, and chose us for His kingdom forever.”* The
- Bread and Wine – is the body and blood of the Lord Jesus Christ, by which we were purchased. /1 Cor. 6:20/



Mystery of Holy Communion

- Preparation for Holy Communion
 - The Holy Communion brings judgment on those who receive it in an unworthy manner.
 - **1 Corinthians 11:29** - *“For he who eats and drinks in an unworthy manner eats and drinks judgment to himself, not discerning the Lord’s body.”*
 - Repentance & Confession:
 - **1 Corinthians 11:28** - *“But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of that bread, and drink of that cup.”*
 - Spiritual and Physical cleanliness (**Matt 22:1-12**)



Mystery of Holy Communion

- Common Questions & wrong assumptions
 - Is Holy Communion truly the body and blood of Jesus Christ or just a symbol?
 - Is it just a remembrance or a real sacrifice?
 - “Do this in remembrance of me.” (**1 Corinthians 11:25**)
 - **1 Cor 11:23 – 26** – “23 For I have received of the Lord that which also I delivered unto you, that the Lord Jesus the same night in which he was betrayed took bread: 24 And when he had given thanks, he broke it, and said, Take, eat: this is my body, which is broken for you: this do in remembrance of me. 25 After the same manner also he took the cup, ... saying, this cup is the new testament in my blood: this do ye, as oft as ye drink it, in remembrance of me. 26 For as often as ye eat this bread, and drink this cup, ye do shew the Lord's death till he come.”



Mystery of Holy Communion

- How can one be worthy of receiving the body and blood of Jesus Christ?
 - “Unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink His blood, you have no life in you.” (John 6:53)
 - When St. Peter said to Jesus Christ, “*Even if I have to die with you, I will not deny you,*” it wasn’t just a lip service, but a conscious and sincere commitment (**Matthew 26:35**). Peter’s denial later, the day after he spoke these words, is not a testimony of Peter’s unfaithfulness, but a testimony of the weakness, and the vulnerability of the flesh. That is why Peter wept bitterly after He denied Jesus three times, remembering the words of Jesus Christ. (**Matthew 26:69-74**).

